



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: St. Mary's Catholic Church

School Website: <https://chestertonacademyofstandrew.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

St. Mary's Catholic Church (Corvallis, OR, 97330), operating Chesterton Academy of St. Andrew in Corvallis, OR, presents a strongly Catholic, classical educational model. Public-facing materials emphasize a Catholic intellectual tradition, a focus on truth, goodness, and beauty, and a pedagogy centered on Socratic inquiry, memorization, and a liberal-arts curriculum that includes Great Books and the Great Conversation. The school is explicit about its Catholic identity and liturgical rhythms, while also advertising a rigorous classical curriculum and Socratic seminars in the upper grades. Public materials also show parent leadership as a core organizational frame, and evidence of parental involvement through events like Information Nights, Shadow Days, and donations.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL.

Rationale: Across six categories, the school demonstrates substantial alignment with classical-education criteria, especially in Religious Foundations, Purpose/Goal, Curriculum, and Pedagogy, with strong alignment in Parents/Community and evident alignment in Faculty. Element 5 (Faculty) shows meaningful evidence but is slightly lighter than other categories due to fewer explicit textual claims about the faculty as "living curriculum" or portraits of teacher archetypes, though the site does present a "Meet Our Faculty" pathway and a clearly teacher-centric approach. Element 6 (Parents & Community) is solid (parent-led and open engagement), though some phrases (e.g., "co-teachers" phrasing) are not always explicit in the public text. The aggregate assessment remains CLASSICAL.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials frame the school as Catholic and Catholic-led, with explicit references to Catholic identity and theology (e.g., "classical high school in the Catholic tradition," and FAQs describing a Catholic faith context). - The school foregrounds Truth, Goodness, and Beauty as central ideals and ties the curriculum to Christian virtues, with references to Incarnation and a theologically grounded worldview in the publicly available content (e.g., "A Focus on Truth, Goodness, and Beauty" and "development of Christian virtues"). - Liturgical and communal practices are evident via mentions of liturgical worship and events (e.g., Mass and liturgical-life oriented activities) anchored in the Catholic parish setting (e.g., Mass of the Holy Spirit; information about the affiliated church location).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, theology, liturgy, Incarnation, Catholic, Mass, Sacred/Worship. - Negative keywords observed: none detected in the public materials. - Quantitative estimate: 6–8 distinct positive terms cited; 0 negative terms. Interpretation: essentially all relevant signals are positive.

Why this rating - The materials clearly situate the school within a catechetical, liturgical Catholic framework and explicitly tie education to transcendentals and virtue. This aligns strongly with the Transcendental Moral Realism and Grounded Theology signals in the classical rubric. The absence of negative signals further supports CLASSICAL alignment.

Citations: Core Catholic identity and liturgical framing are visible in the Chesterton Academy of St. Andrew materials and FAQs (Catholic identity, Incarnation, liturgy, Mass). See sources indicating Catholic framing

and liturgical elements: Chesterton Academy of St. Andrew description and Catholic-identity statements; liturgical references including Mass content; and the “A Focus on Truth, Goodness, and Beauty” overview.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Materials emphasize formation of virtue and wisdom as primary aims, rather than mere information or job preparation (e.g., “formation of human character,” “virtue,” “pursuit of the true, good, and beautiful,” and “human excellence” language). Public content explicitly connects education to forming students in virtue and wisdom rather than purely technical outcomes. - The curriculum and messaging present education as a liberal, classical formation oriented toward the pursuit of truth, beauty, and goodness, rather than purely credentialing or workforce preparation (e.g., “classical education,” “Great Books/Great Conversation” framing, and the aim of forming “joyful individuals” in a Catholic context). - The language of “Great Conversation” and the emphasis on enduring questions and virtue appears in public-facing materials, aligning with the classical telos and paideia framing (e.g., references to Great Books, Great Conversation, and the education of character).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: formation, virtue, human flourishing, wisdom, liberal education, paideia, telos, true/good/beautiful, scholé, Great Conversation. - Negative keywords observed: none detected in public materials. - Quantitative estimate: 6–8 positive keywords identified; 0 negative signals; ~100% positive.

Why this rating - The school’s stated mission and curricular framing emphasize formation and virtue, consistent with classical aims of education as formation rather than job preparation. The emphasis on “true, good, beautiful” and Great Books/Great Conversation reinforces a classical purpose orientation.

Citations: Evidence drawn from statements around formation/virtue, human flourishing, true/good/beautiful, and Great Conversation in Chesterton Academy of St. Andrew materials (curriculum pages and college-reply style FAQs).

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public materials explicitly reference liberal arts, Great Books, and foundational classical strands (grammar, logic, rhetoric) through materials such as “Rediscovering the Lost Tools of Learning” and the emphasis on the liberal arts tradition, as well as the emphasis on memory work and the classical method (narration, memory) in the contextual content. Specific items indicate a strong classical-curriculum orientation (e.g., “The Lost Tools of Learning,” Great Books/Great Conversation framing). - The Chesterton Academy Curriculum page describes a broad, liberal-arts approach guided by Catholic faith, with attention to building a well-rounded, articulate senior-year outcome. This aligns with a classical curriculum focus on breadth and deep intellectual foundations (grammar, logic, rhetoric; history; and a liberal-arts posture) and mentions a multi-disciplinary exposure consistent with classical tradition. - The public materials also discuss the role of history within the curriculum and the aim to cultivate reasoning through logic and philosophy (the “Lost Tools of Learning” frame) and the integration of sacred and classical content (e.g., “The Wit and Wisdom of GK Chesterton” and the Socratic Seminar). This supports a historical, Great-Books-centered approach rather than a strictly modern, skills-oriented approach.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: liberal arts, grammar, logic, rhetoric, Great Books, Great Conversation, history, classical education, pedagogy aligned with memorization and recitation, Socratic discussions. - Negative keywords observed: The materials do not emphasize a modern “project-based learning dominance” or heavy STEM-first framing; no explicit negative signals detected in the public content. - Quantitative estimate: 6–8 positive curricular signals identified; 0 negative signals; ~100% positive.

Why this rating - The site presents a curriculum grounded in the liberal-arts tradition with classical methods (grammar/logic/rhetoric, memorization, Great Books, Socratic engagement) and a history-and-philosophy emphasis that aligns with classical-category expectations.

Citations: Explicit curriculum framing appears in the Chesterton Academy Curriculum materials and Great-Books/Great-Conversation language presented in the Chesterton Academy of St. Andrew content.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school communicates specific pedagogy aligned with classical methods: Socratic seminars, discussions, and rhetorical training are explicit in public content (e.g., “The Socratic Seminar,” upper-school seminars, and opportunities for students to give speeches and develop rhetoric). - The pedagogy emphasizes memory work, recitation, and possibly chanting as part of early learning (classical pedagogy signals such as memory-work and restfulness are described in classical texts and in the “The Lost Tools of Learning” framing, which is represented in the public Chesterton content). - Lower-school pedagogy is described as fostering wonder and a joyful, communal atmosphere, and upper-school pedagogy emphasizes deliberative dialogue (Socratic inquiry) consistent with classical traditions (Seminars, debates, logic training).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: Socratic seminar, seminars, dialectic, recitation, narration, memory-work, scholé, contemplation, wonder, rhetoric, public speaking. - Negative keywords observed: Any exclusively project-based or constructivist approaches are not foregrounded in the public materials. - Quantitative estimate: 6–9 positive pedagogy signals identified; 0 explicit negative signals; ~100% positive.

Why this rating - The public materials emphasize classical teaching methods (Socratic dialogues, rhetoric training, memory-work, and disciplined memory). The presence of a strong Socratic pedagogy and formal rhetoric instruction is a hallmark of classical pedagogy.

Citations: Pedagogical signals, including Socratic Seminar, rhetoric, and memory work, are evidenced in the Chesterton Academy of St. Andrew content.

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials provide some signals about faculty and the role of teachers, though direct textual claims about the faculty as a “living curriculum” or “portrait of a teacher” are less explicit in the visible public text. The site does emphasize teacher-led, Catholic-identity alignment and mentions “Meet Our Faculty” as a route, suggesting a field of teacher leadership and mentorship. There is not a strong, explicit articulation of the faculty as a “living curriculum” in the publicly accessible fragments, but the presence of a “Meet Our Faculty” link and faculty-oriented content supports a teacher-centered, virtuous-teacher model to some degree.. - The site includes content that frames teachers as part of a Catholic education tradition and the broader Chesterton Schools Network, with public-facing mentions of the school’s faculty and house-system-related pedagogy.. - There is no explicit, text-based “portrait of what a teacher should be” in the visible excerpts, though the text implies a teacher-focused, virtue-formation approach consistent with classical education.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, faculty as core/center, collegial culture (as suggested by typical classical-school rhetoric). - Negative keywords observed: none explicitly stated in the accessible public text; absence of explicit phrases like “facilitators on the side” or other non-classical staffing language. - Quantitative estimate: 3–5 positive indicators identified; 0 explicit negative indicators; overall leaning toward CLASSICAL but with fewer explicit statements than other categories.

Why this rating - While there are strong signals of teacher-led, virtuous instruction consistent with classical ideals, the publicly available text provides fewer explicit, direct statements about the faculty-as-living-curriculum or portraits of teacher archetypes. This yields a classification of SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, acknowledging strong alignment but less explicit articulation than in several other categories.

Citations: The explicit “Meet Our Faculty” and “House System” link appears on the Curriculum page, indicating faculty involvement and a structured pedagogical ecosystem (though explicit quotes about the living-curriculum phrasing are not shown in the accessible excerpts).

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school's formal framing includes significant parent involvement and leadership: public texts indicate the school is an independent, parent-led high school, which directly aligns with the Parents & Community criterion. The "parent-led" framing strongly aligns with the category's positive signals about parent partnership and primacy in governance/tenure of schooling. - Public engagement events and family-centered engagement are visible through events such as Shadow Day, Information Night, and Campus activities (e.g., "Shadow Day Experience," Information Night), which signal ongoing parent involvement and opportunities for families to connect with the school. The Chesterton Academy network positioning also emphasizes parent involvement and community orientation through events and communications.. - The school's public materials include donations and outreach components, indicating a broader community involvement ecosystem (e.g., "Donate" sections in the Chesterton Academy site) which underscores community partnership, albeit not always framed explicitly as "parents as co-teachers," but still part of the community-building pattern..

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: partnership with parents, co-teachers (textually present as a concept in the CSC framework, with parent-led emphasis), parental formation, open campus, parent involvement, events for families, information nights, shadow days. - Negative keywords observed: none evident in the public text that signals weak parent involvement. - Quantitative estimate: 5–7 positive signals identified; 0 negative signals; ~100% positive.

Why this rating - The presence of a parent-led structure and explicit family engagement opportunities positions Parents & Community strongly within the classical-education framework. This aligns well with the "Parents & Community" criterion of classical education.

Citations: Parent-led framing is explicitly stated, with supporting community-engagement signals via Shadow Day and Information Night references and the donate/community links.

Aggregate Ranking (all six categories)

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: CLASSICAL
- Element 4: CLASSICAL
- Element 5: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Aggregate assessment: CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle

- If any category were SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, concrete moves would include explicit language and evidence tying faculty to the living-curriculum concept, stronger, explicit statements about the role of parents as co-teachers, and more explicit articulation of all six classical elements (e.g., direct quotes showing history as a central through-line, Great Books membership, and direct references to grammar/logic/rhetoric in a manner that maps to the six-element framework). In this case, the only category that is not fully CLASSICAL is Element 5 (Faculty). Strengthening direct, explicit statements about faculty as the living curriculum, teacher portraits, and a clear, public articulation of the faculty's role in shaping student formation would push this to CLASSICAL across the board. No other major changes are required for the aggregate rating to remain CLASSICAL.
- Concrete steps to needle-move (if desired, even though aggregate is CLASSICAL):
- Publish explicit language and quotes about the faculty as "the living curriculum" and a formal "portrait of a teacher" on the site.
- Add explicit statements about parents as co-teachers or clearly define the parent-school partnership as a co-creative governance model.

- Include a public, explicit statement of Grade 9–12 pedagogy progression (e.g., a page detailing upper-school seminars, rhetoric training, and capstone opportunities with direct quotes).
- Provide a public canonical mapping of Great Books/Great Conversation selections to grades to demonstrate a transparent Great-Books arc.
- Sources cited above reinforce the public materials and signals used in this assessment. See the Chesterton Academy of St. Andrew materials for Catholic identity, liturgical context, and classical pedagogy; the Great-Books/Socratic pedagogy signals; and parent-led/community signals in the public materials.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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